No Excuses: Existentialism and the Meaning of Life

Nietzsche is ultimately a virtue ethicist in the classical Greek tradition. The master morality holds in high regard the excellences that promote flourishing. The slave morality is one of resentment posed as a stance against what the masters hold dear. Christianity took a stance against wealth because the masters held it in high regard. My own take, and I'm not sure it fully holds up: for all the talk of the Ubermensch creating his own morality, it's tempting to imagine he'd land on cooperation and "being good" out of pure self-interest, since non-zero-sum gains make cooperation worthwhile; he just wouldn't value the reactionary morals promoted by the slave. But that's a Hobbesian, payoff-driven argument for morality, and Nietzsche had contempt for exactly that kind of utility-justified "goodness"

- it's the sort of herd reasoning he spent Beyond Good and Evil attacking. Master-morality virtues are supposed to be affirmed for their own sake (self-overcoming, rank, contempt for weakness), not because they happen to pay off socially. So I like the tidiness of "the Ubermensch is basically a good, generous, self-forgetting cooperator" - his biography as a genuinely kind friend supports it, and the state in which we hurt others is seldom as agreeable as that in which we benefit them - but I don't think it's a clean resolution. There's real hardness and contempt for the weak in the text that this reading smooths over. Nietzschean morality isn't a harsh LaVeyan construction, but it isn't the tame thing I want it to be either.

The lecture title "No Excuses" comes from Sartre's concept of Absolute Freedom. Even if chained in a dungeon, you are absolutely free. Clearly you aren't free to leave. But you are free to form your own opinion of the facts, no matter what it may be. You might consider your punishment well earned and focus on penance. Or you might consider it unjust and rage against your oppressors. On the other hand, you could consider it the perfect opportunity to be the model prisoner and act as such. No matter what, you choose your interpretation and reaction. Even emotions are a choice in what is consciously indulged and resisted, but on this he may be wrong. We don't choose war, but we get the war we deserve by acting as good or bad people within our predetermined background events. Your feelings about events magically transform the world; the sour grapes really are sour. Dennett would approve of his stance that consciousness is freedom.

Another important concept of Sartre's is "Bad Faith." It's a bit subtle, but basically you have the facticity of yourself, just the facts, history, and the transcendent self, what you aspire to and

your personal choice. If your transcendent self fails to accept the facts, you are acting in "Bad Faith." For a mundane example, I could aspire to be a champion basketball player, but the facts say I'm 5'11" and almost 50 years old. If I aspired to be that champion, it would be in bad faith. For a more serious example, if your actions are immoral but you aspire to be and think of yourself as a good person, it is in bad faith. It is also in bad faith to define yourself as what other people think or even in rebellion to what other people think.